“What Should Happen First?”

Eight questions families ask when several care decisions arrive at once, answered in plain terms.

When a discharge date, a rehab's question and a pharmacy's questions land in the same week, most families ask the same few things, usually in a hallway. Here they are, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about your husband in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows him, the answer says who to ask.

1 What should happen first?

In general: the decision with the nearest date that somebody actually gave you, and ahead of it, the things that decision depends on. AARP's planning guide describes a similar first pass: determine whether there is an immediate need in each area, and where nothing is pressing, prioritize the tasks and develop a timeline. Which decision that is for your family depends on dates and facts this page can't see. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** two dates seem to collide, or nobody will confirm one. Ask the discharge planner or the person who set it.

2 Who is responsible?

It depends on what for. His medical care belongs to his clinicians, and the planning for his discharge may be handled by a discharge planner, a social worker, a nurse or another member of the hospital staff. For the family's tasks, the answer is whoever has agreed to each one. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests writing down what each person has agreed to, as a reminder everyone can go back to. [2] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell who at the hospital is handling his discharge. Ask the staff who your point person is, and write down the name and number.

3 What must be clarified before we act?

Whatever the next decision depends on. Often that is a short list of facts, and some of them belong to a doctor, a pharmacist or a social worker, not to the family. Medicare's discharge checklist tells caregivers to write down their questions about the discharge instructions and discuss them with the staff. Write each open item with the name of the person who can settle it. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** an item on that list is about his health, his medicines or his safety. Those belong to his clinicians.

4 How do we know which deadlines are real?

Ask the person who set it. A date with a name beside it was given to you. A date the family has been working to without being told is still a question. Whatever you learn, write it down with the day and who you spoke with, as the Family Caregiver Alliance advises for calls about services. [5] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the date in question is the discharge itself. Only a physician can authorize a patient's release from the hospital, so take questions about it to his doctor or the discharge planner.

5 What's the difference between a decision and a task?

A decision is a choice somebody has to make. A task is something somebody has to do. A third kind, an open question, is something to find out. On one long list they look alike, which is part of why everything feels due at once. Sorting them often leaves a decisions list that is shorter than you expected.

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell whether a choice is the family's to make or a clinician's. Ask the clinician.

6 My name is beside almost every task. How do we share the work?

It usually isn't planned that way. The Family Caregiver Alliance, writing about brothers and sisters caring for a parent, notes that the others may assume the one doing the work has everything covered. AARP's planning guide says caring for a family member can be too big a job for one person. Sharing starts with asking: MedlinePlus suggests making a list of ways others can help and letting helpers choose what they'd like to do. [6] [1] [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you notice you're feeling overwhelmed, alone in it, or tired most of the time. MedlinePlus lists those among the signs of caregiver stress. Mention them to your own doctor.

7 Does my husband get a say in what comes first?

Yes. AARP's guide says every family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and should never be made without his participation, knowledge and consent. Medicare's checklist, written to the patient, says to ask where care will be given after discharge and to tell the staff what you prefer. Write his wishes down in his own words, and keep them separate from the family's. [1] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** he and the family want different things. Keep both written down, and bring both to his doctor, the social worker or your care consultant.

8 Where do we take a question nobody in the family can answer?

To the person it belongs to. Questions about his health, his medicines or his safety go to his doctor, his nurse or his pharmacist, and questions about the discharge go to the discharge planner or social worker. A professional care manager, the Family Caregiver Alliance says, is trained to assess an individual situation and to implement and monitor a care plan. To find services in your community, the Eldercare Locator, a public service of the Administration for Community Living, is at 1-800-677-1116. [5] [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell which kind of professional a question belongs to. Ask any of them. Identifying which professionals need to be involved is also part of your care consultant's work at this step.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about your husband himself, and it doesn't say which of your family's decisions comes first. Anything that depends on his condition, his medicines or his safety needs someone who has assessed him.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions. The care interview is where the questions become about your husband: it walks you through his situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
4. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
7. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine, NIH), Caregiver Health
8. Administration for Community Living, Eldercare Locator